

Notes on Radio Evolution of Galaxies

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Chapter 1

Useful Terminology and Concepts

TODO

- need to add Initial Mass Function stuff at some point.
- need to add info about emission lines of x rays (detecting hot gas $\sim 10^7$ K), $H\alpha$ lines (detecting warm gas $\sim 10^4$ K), HI (21 cm) lines (detecting cold gas ~ 100 K).
- From sec 9.6 in Schneider, need to add info about star formation detection, IMF and other stuff. Whole treasure trove is there.
- X-factor conversion for estimation of H_2 abundance given we know CO abundance.
- permitted and forbidden transitions, this kinda adds to the absorption lines part.
- how exactly doppler effect and redshift works.

Books used:

1. **Reference 1:** *Extragalactic Astronomy and Cosmology* by Peter Schneider.
2. **Reference 2:** *An Introduction to Galaxies and Cosmology* by Jones M. H., Lambourne R. J.

1.1 Basic Terminology

need to add magnitude concise defns, colour index followed.

- i. add parsec defn
- ii. **Luminosity (L):** The total amount of electromagnetic **energy emitted per unit time** by an astronomical object. The total luminosity from an isotropic source is:

$$L = \int dA I(R) = \int_0^{2\pi} \int_0^\infty d\theta dR I(R) R$$

- iii. **Radiant Flux Density (S):** The total amount of electromagnetic **energy per unit area per unit time** by an astronomical object. In other words, it is the luminosity per unit

area. According to this definition, at a distance D from a star (say):

$$S = \frac{L}{4\pi D^2}$$

- iv. **Effective Temperature** (T_{eff}): The effective temperature of a body such as a star or planet is the temperature of a black body of the same radius that would emit the same total energy as electromagnetic radiation.
- v. **Effective Radius** (R_e): Defined such that half of the luminosity of a galaxy is emitted from within this radius.

$$\int_0^{R_e} dR I(R)R = \frac{1}{2} \int_0^{\infty} dR I(R)R$$

- vi. **Effective Intensity** (I_e): $I_e = I(R_e)$; Total intensity from within the effective radius.
- vii. **Colour Temperature** (T_c): The temperature of a black body such that it has the same colour index as that of an astral body.
- viii. **Specific Luminosity** (L_ν): The energy emitted per unit time for a unit frequency range.
- ix. **Rotation Curves**: Rotational velocity (v) of stars and gas around the galactic center as a function the galacto-centric radius¹ R .
- x. **Spectral Energy Distribution (SED)**: The logarithmic plot of λF_λ vs. λ , representing the broadband spectrum (energy distribution over all observed wavelength ranges) of an astral body.
- xi. **Globular Clusters**: A globular cluster is defined as a gravitationally bound collection of typically several hundred thousand stars contained within a spherical region with a radius of approximately 20 parsecs (pc). The members of the cluster orbit according to the gravitational potential of the cluster while the cluster as a whole orbits the center of the galaxy.
- xii. **Variability Time Scale**: Characteristic duration during which the radiative flux from an astral body changes significantly. This is very useful for estimating physical sizes. For instance, sometimes the flux from AGNs can change even by 50% on a single day, indicating that the emitting region is small.

xiii. add sun units, $\odot$

Spiral Galaxy Specific

- i. **Scale-length** (h_R): The radius at which the surface brightness of the galaxy is a factor of e less than at the center.

¹Distance from the center of the galaxy.

- ii. **Scale-height** (h_z): The radius at which the surface brightness of the galaxy (edge-on) is a factor of e less than at the center.

1.2 Relevant Title Required

1.2.1 Strength and Width of Emission Lines

To characterize the strength of an emission line, we define the *equivalent width* of a line W_λ as:

$$W_\lambda = \int d\lambda \frac{S(\lambda) - S_c(\lambda)}{S_c(\lambda)} \approx \frac{F_{\text{line}}}{S_c(\lambda_0)}$$

where $S(\lambda)$ is the total spectral flux, and $S_c(\lambda)$ is the spectral flux of the continuum radiation interpolated across the wavelength range of the line. F_{line} is the total flux in the line and λ_0 its wavelength. Hence, W_λ is the width of the wavelength interval over which the continuum needs to be integrated to obtain the same flux as measured in the line. Therefore, the equivalent width is a measure of the strength of a line relative to the continuum intensity.

The *width* of a line is characterized as follows: after subtracting the continuum, interpolated across the wavelength range of the line, the width is measured at half of the maximum line intensity. This width $\Delta\lambda$ is called the FWHM (full width at half maximum); it may be specified either in Å, or in km/s if the line width is interpreted as Doppler broadening, with $\Delta\lambda/\lambda = \Delta v/c$. It should be noted that the width $\Delta\lambda$ and the equivalent width W_λ are very different quantities. For example, a strong narrow line can have a large W_λ , but a small $\Delta\lambda$. Conversely, a weak broad emission line can have $\Delta\lambda \gg W_\lambda$.

NEED TO PROPERLY UNDERSTAND THIS LATER

1.3 Blackbody Radiation

A very brief explanation of blackbody radiation includes the Stefan-Boltzmann Law which states that the flux S for a perfect blackbody is given by:

$$S = \sigma T^4 \tag{1.1}$$

where $\sigma = 5.67 \times 10^{-5} \text{ erg cm}^{-2} \text{ K}^{-4} \text{ s}^{-1}$ is the Stefan-Boltzmann constant.

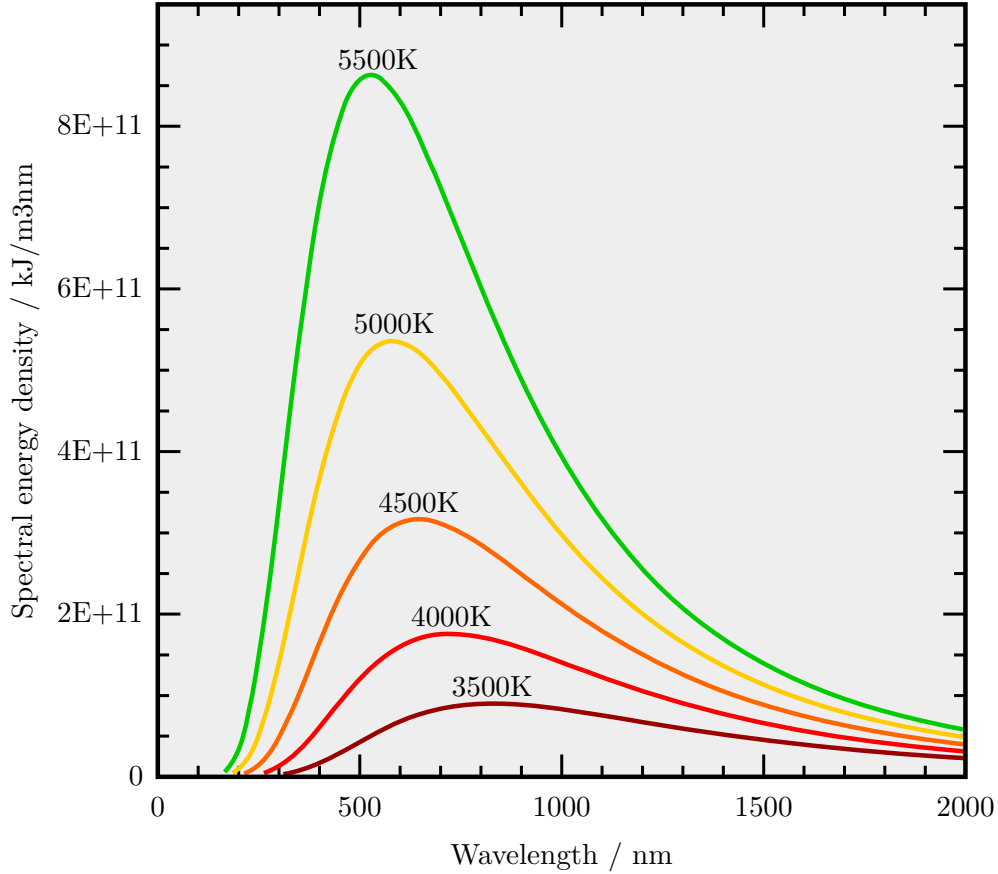
Additionally, for a blackbody, it helps to know the Wien's Displacement Law which states that the emission curve for blackbodies peak at different wavelengths which is inversely proportional to its temperature:

$$\lambda_{\text{peak}} = \frac{b}{T} \tag{1.2}$$

where $b \approx 2.898 \times 10^6 \text{ nm K}$.

1.4 The Magnitude Scale

Our eyes judge brightness according in a logarithmic fashion, similar to hearing. This means that what we perceive to be twice as bright is actually emitting a lot more than just twice the radiant energy. Due to this, optical astronomy uses 'magnitude' as a scale of brightness.



1.4.1 Apparent Magnitude

The purpose of apparent magnitude is to closely match visually reported magnitudes and quantify these historical observations. It is a measure for the radiant flux S from a body. For two sources with fluxes S_1 and S_2 , their *apparent magnitudes* m_1 and m_2 are defined as:

$$m_1 - m_2 = -2.5 \log\left(\frac{S_1}{S_2}\right)$$

This means that a brighter object will have a smaller apparent magnitude. The factor of 2.5 is chosen to most accurately match the historically reported magnitudes. A more *absolute* definition can be found below in the next section, which depends on the filter in consideration.

1.4.2 Filters and Colour

Optical observations are performed with a combination of filters and detectors. Since the spectral energy distribution is not necessarily uniform over all wavelengths, apparent magnitudes are defined for each of these filters, i.e. apparent magnitude is a function of the wavelength of light being considered.

Vega Magnitude

$$m = m(\lambda) \equiv m_X \equiv X$$

where X is the filter for some specific wavelength λ .

The magnitudes of the different filters are related, by definition, as $U = B = V = R = I = \dots$ for main sequence stars of spectral type A0 (Vega is an archetype of such stars), i.e., every colour index for such a star is defined to be zero.

For a more precise definition, let $T_X(\nu)$ be the transmission curve of the filter-detector system. $T_X(\nu)$ specifies which fraction of the incoming photons with frequency are registered by the detector. The apparent magnitude of a source with spectral flux S_ν is then:

$$m_X = -2.5 \log \left(\frac{\int d\nu T_X(\nu) S_\nu}{\int d\nu T_X(\nu)} \right) + \text{const.}$$

The argument of the logarithm is the average flux received in total for the entire EM spectrum. The constant is determined from reference stars. This is also referred to as the Vega apparent magnitude.

AB Magnitude

Another commonly used definition, does not consider the spectral energy distribution of reference. The reference is instead defined as constant flux at all frequencies, $S_\nu^{\text{ref}} = S_\nu^{\text{AB}} = 2.89 \times 10^{-21} \text{ erg s}^{-1} \text{ cm}^{-2} \text{ Hz}^{-1}$. This value makes A0 stars like Vega have the same magnitude in the original Johnson-V-band as in the AB system.

1.4.3 Absolute Magnitude

Since apparent magnitude does not reveal any information about the luminosity of the body since it inherently depends on the distance of the body from Earth. If we are at a distance D from a body and L_ν (energy per unit time for unit frequency range) is its specific luminosity, the flux for isotropic emission is given by:

$$S_\nu = \frac{L_\nu}{4\pi D^2} \quad (1.3)$$

To reveal the physical properties of the source itself irrespective of how it appears to us, we define absolute magnitude, M_X , where X refers to the filter under consideration. It is defined to be the apparent magnitude of a body at a distance of 10 pc from us. Its relation to the apparent magnitude is as follows:

$$m_X - M_X = 5 \log \left(\frac{D}{1 \text{ pc}} \right) - 5 \equiv \mu$$

where μ is called the *distance modulus*. Hence, the latter is a logarithmic measure of the distance of a source: $\mu = 0$ for $D = 10 \text{ pc}$, $\mu = 10$ for $D = 1 \text{ kpc}$, and $\mu = 25$ for $D = 1 \text{ Mpc}$. The difference between apparent and absolute magnitude is independent of the filter choice, and it equals the distance modulus if no extinction is present. In general, this difference is modified by the wavelength (and thus filter) dependent extinction coefficient.

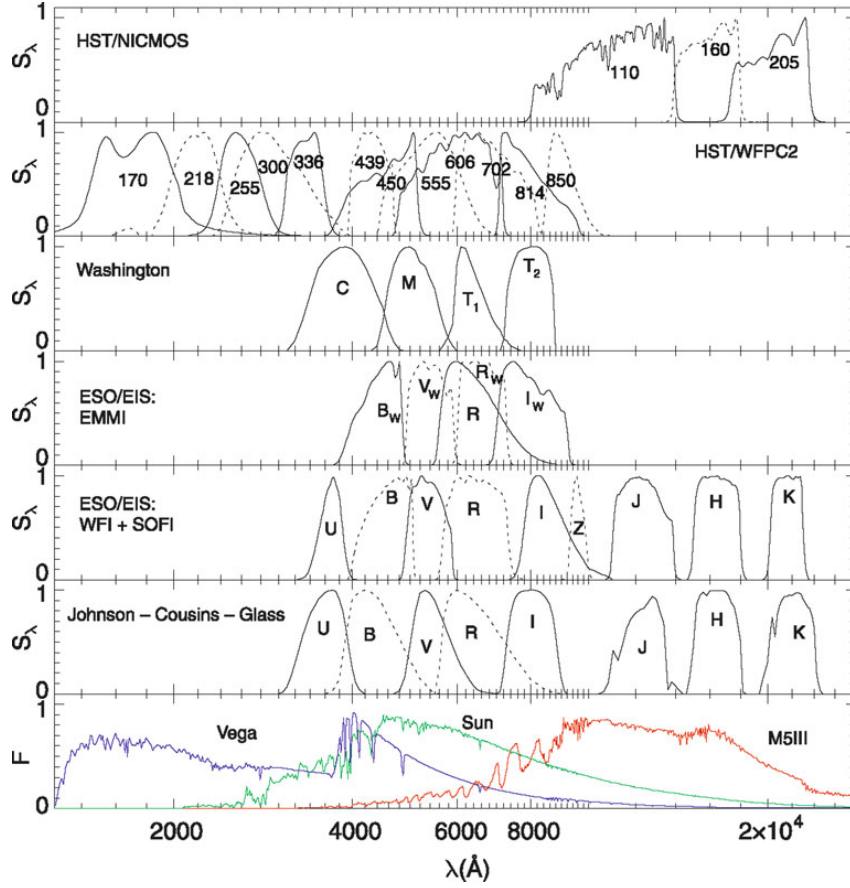


Figure 1.1: This shows the transmission curves of different spectra. At the bottom, we have the spectra of 3 stars with different effective temperatures.

1.4.4 Bolometric Parameters

The total flux S and luminosity L over all frequencies are naturally be defined as:

$$S = \int_0^{\infty} S_{\nu} d\nu; \quad L = \int_0^{\infty} L_{\nu} d\nu$$

These define the *bolometric magnitudes*:

$$m_{\text{bol}} = -2.5 \log(S) + \text{const.}$$

$$M_{\text{bol}} = -2.5 \log(L) + \text{const.}$$

The constants can be determined from reference stars. In particular, using the sun as reference with $m_{\odot \text{bol}} = -26.83$ and the distance of 1 a.u. gives $\mu = -31.47$, thus giving us:

$$M_{\odot \text{bol}} = m_{\odot \text{bol}} - \mu = 4.74$$

From this, we obtain:

$$M_{\text{bol}} = 4.74 - 2.5 \log \left(\frac{L}{L_{\odot}} \right)$$

where the luminosity of the sun is $L_{\odot} = 3.85 \times 10^{33} \text{ erg s}^{-1}$. To obtain a value for the luminosity for galaxies or AGNs², we use the relative definition of absolute magnitude to write:

$$L_X = 10^{-0.4(M_X - M_{\odot X})} L_{\odot X} \quad (1.4)$$

where X represents the X-band filter.

1.5 Stars

Stars can be reasonably thought of as gas spheres, in the cores of which light atomic nuclei fuse into heavier ones (mostly hydrogen to helium) by thermonuclear processes, thereby producing energy. **External appearance of stars** is primarily determined by their radii R and their temperature T . **Properties and evolution of stars** is primarily governed by their masses M .

1.5.1 Parameters of Stars

For a first approximation, the spectral energy distribution of a star's emission can be described by blackbody radiation, where the flux S is given by the Stefan-Boltzmann equation (1.1). Thus, the luminosity for the star at a distance R is given by (1.3):

$$L = 4\pi R^2 \sigma T^4$$

Stars deviate from this profile and we define effective temperature (iv.) as:

$$\sigma T_{\text{eff}}^4 \equiv \frac{L}{4\pi R^2} \quad (1.5)$$

The luminosities can range from $10^{-4} L_{\odot}$ to $10^5 L_{\odot}$.

The temperature of a star can be estimated from its colour. Again, to a first approximation, Wien's displacement law (1.2) can explain the colour of stars depending upon temperature. [mention how redshift gets factored in here, found relevant thread here.](#)

Using the colour index $X - Y \equiv m_X - m_Y$ in two filters X and Y lets us find the colour temperature T_c (vii.) of the star. For a perfect blackbody, $T_c = T_{\text{eff}}$ but in general they differ.

1.5.2 Classification of Stars

The Harvard sequence of stellar spectra classifies stars according to the **widths and ratios of their atomic spectral lines**. This is essentially a classification based on **colour temperature** T_c since the transitions leading to those spectral lines are directly dependent on the temperature of the region.

The sequence of **spectral classes** is denoted in the order O, B, A, F, G, K, M in decreasing

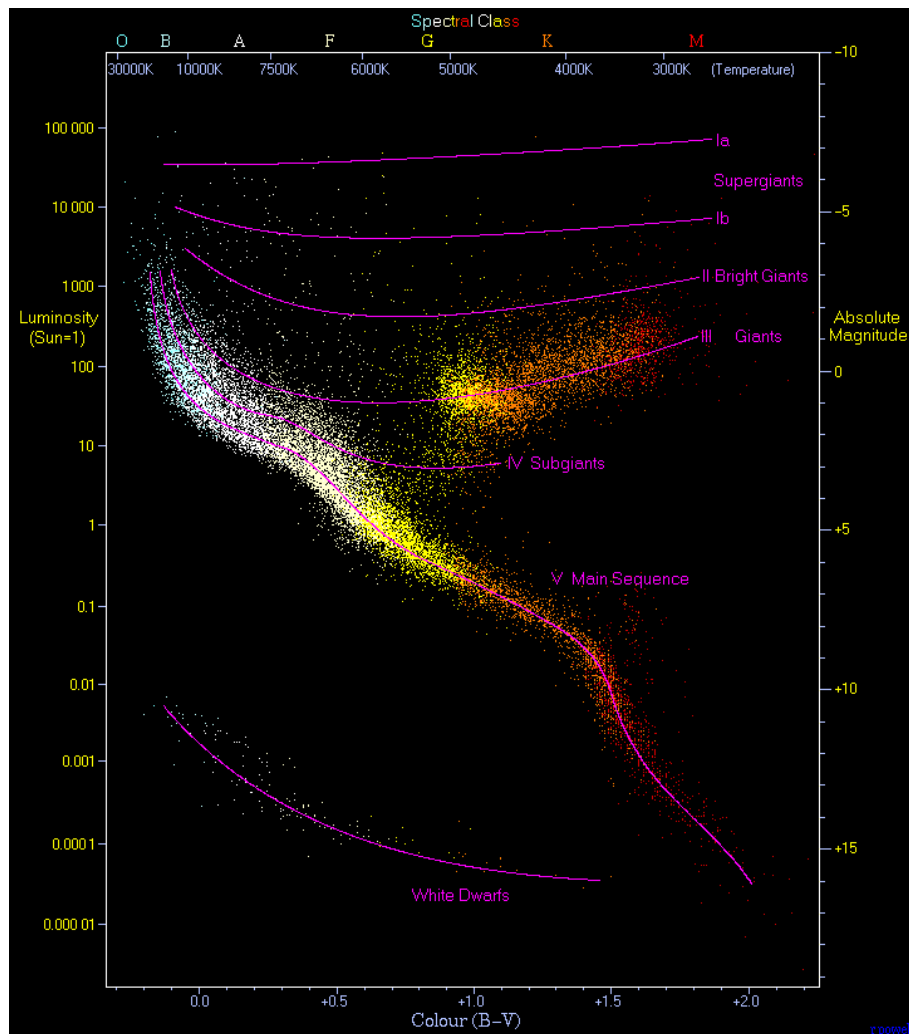
²Active Galactic Nuclei (AGN) are galaxies whose largest fraction of luminosity is produced in a very small central region: the active galactic nucleus.

order of colour temperature. Each spectral class is further subclassified using digits 0 to 9, again in descending order of colour temperature. For instance, our Sun is a G2 star.

Hertzsprung-Russell Diagram (HRD): Absolute magnitude vs. spectral classes.

Colour-Magnitude Diagram (CMD): Absolute magnitude vs. colour index (like $B - V$ or $V - I$)

Both of these diagrams yield a very characteristic central result of astronomy which says that most stars are arranged along a 1-dimensional sequence - the main sequence. Luminosity L vs effective temperature T_{eff} also yields a different but very similar graph.



Based on luminosity, the stars can be classified into **luminosity classes**:

Class I Supergiants; Class II Bright giants

Class III Giants; Class IV Subgiants

Class V Dwarfs; Class VI Subdwarfs

Our sun is a luminosity class V dwarf.

Since stars exist which have, for the same spectral type and hence the same color temperature (and roughly the same effective temperature), very different luminosities, we can deduce immediately that these stars have different radii from the equation of effective temperature (1.5). Thus the red giants which have the same effective temperatures as the main sequence stars must

have much larger radii.

Spectroscopically, the width of spectral absorption lines depends on gravitational acceleration on star's surface, $g = \frac{GM}{R^2}$, according to models of stellar atmosphere. It is based on these line widths (and thus luminosity) that we obtain the different luminosity classes.

If we have the distance of a star (thus its luminosity) and if its surface gravity can be derived from the line width, we can obtain the **stellar mass**. For the **main sequence stars**, this turns out to be approximately:

$$\frac{L}{L_{\odot}} \approx \left(\frac{M}{M_{\odot}} \right)^{3.5} \quad (1.6)$$

Sun

The solar spectrum peaks at around 501 nm, which looks green ish to me. According to Wien's law, assuming blackbody, the surface temperature of the sun is estimated to be:

$$T_{\text{eff}} = \frac{b}{501 \text{ nm}} \approx 5784.431\text{K}$$

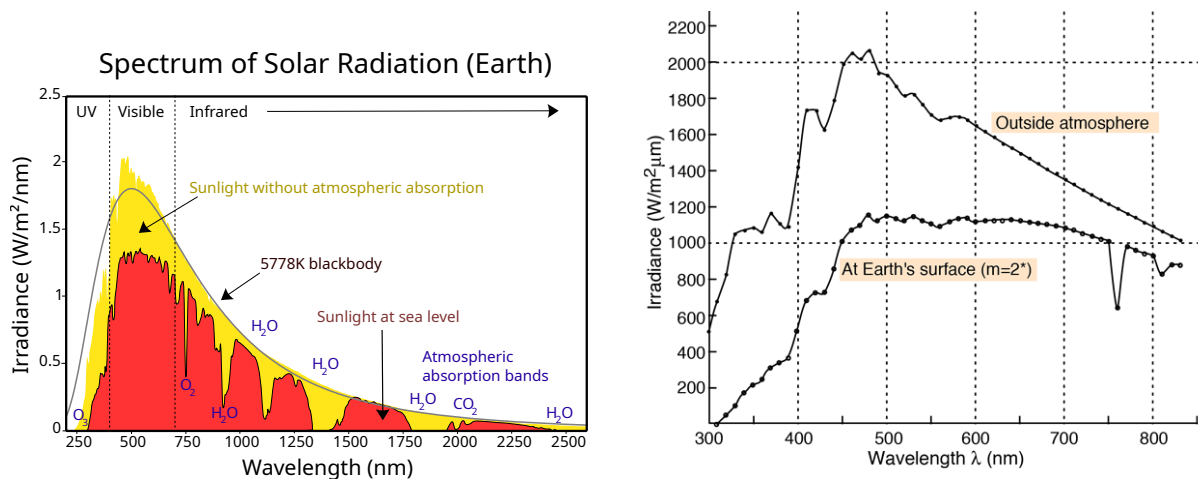


Figure 1.2: Solar Spectrum, G2 Type Star

1.5.3 Spectra of Some Stars

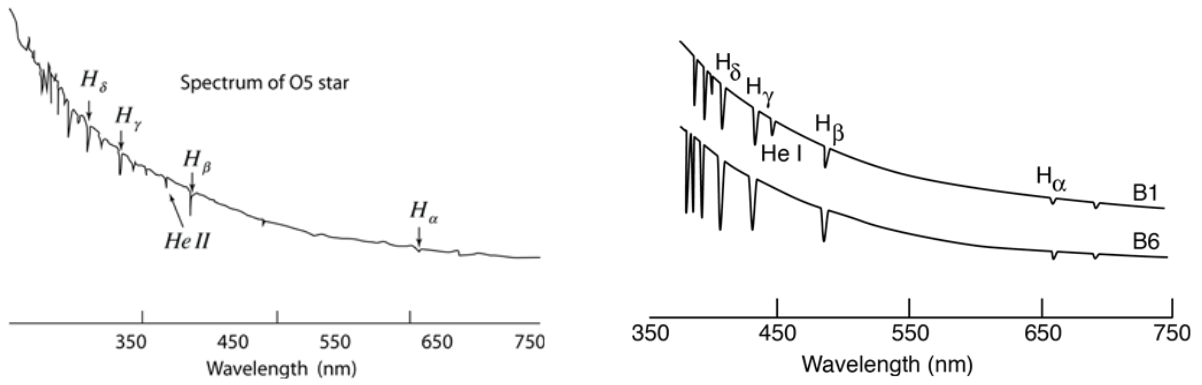


Figure 1.3: Spectrum of an O5 Type Star (left) and B Type Stars (right).

The different spectral types have different effective temperatures. This is demonstrated in their emission spectra where the earlier stars have a smaller peak wavelength, thus appearing bluer.

1.5.4 Structure and Evolution of Stars

Add how stars are formed from cool gas through gravitational forces mainly.

Stars are almost spherically symmetric, so we consider its parameters as radial functions: Pressure, Density, Temperature and Chemical Composition. Stars are almost always in hydrostatic equilibrium, with the pressure fighting against its own gravitational pull.

Fusion at the Center and Transport of Energy

In the center of a star, the density and temperature are high enough to cause thermonuclear ignition, causing the formation of Helium from Hydrogen (4 protons combine into ${}^4\text{He}$ nucleus). This fusion results in energy release that is transported outwards in the form of radiation transport or through convection of stellar plasma. It is then released in the form of electromagnetic waves from the star. The chemical composition is homogenous in the convection zones as they transport and mix the stellar material.

A part of the energy released is in form of neutrinos that can escape unobstructed from stars because of their low cross-section³.

Temperature Dependence of Energy Production Rate

For temperatures below around 15×10^6 K, the energy production rate is approximately proportional to T^4 , where the reaction follows the ‘pp-chain’. Above that, the reaction follows the ‘CNO cycle’ where the rate is roughly proportional to T^{20} .

Lifetime of a Star

Beginning with homogenous chemical composition, if the stars have masses above $\sim 0.08M_{\odot}$, only then do they have enough temperature and pressure in their core to fuse hydrogen into helium. Otherwise, they are called brown dwarfs which aren’t exactly stars in the proper sense.

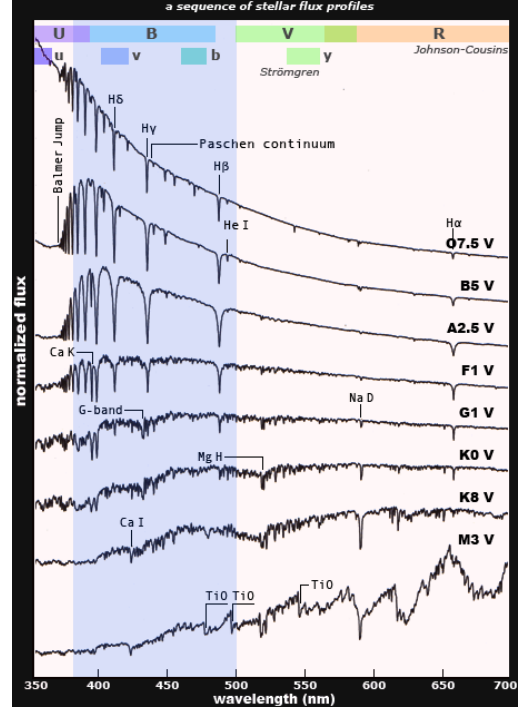


Figure 1.4: The spectra of the different spec-

³Cross-section is a measure related to the probability that a specific process will take place in a collision of two particles. In this case, it is referring to the probability that a neutrino will interact with matter.

At the onset of nuclear fusion, the star is located on the Zero-Age Main Sequence (ZAMS) in the HRD. With the conversion of hydrogen into helium, the chemical composition changes and the conditions in a star will change considerably once roughly 10% of its hydrogen is used up. At that point, the stars will move away from the main sequence. This allows us to estimate the life of a star on the main sequence. The total energy produced in this phase is:

$$E_{\text{MS}} = 0.1 \times M c^2 \times 0.007$$

where $M c^2$ is the rest mass of the star and 0.007 is the efficiency of the conversion. We know that luminosity is energy per unit time, so this energy is equivalent to the product of the luminosity in this period with the time period t_{MS} :

$$t_{\text{MS}} = \frac{E_{\text{MS}}}{L} \approx 8 \times 10^9 \frac{M/M_{\odot}}{L/L_{\odot}} \text{ yr} \approx 8 \times 10^9 \left(\frac{M}{M_{\odot}} \right)^{-2.5} \text{ yr}$$

where we used the fact that the luminosity is a steep function of the stellar mass (1.6).

Thus, heavier the star, lesser the time it spends on the main sequence. A G star like our sun stays in the main sequence for about 8-10 billion years, whereas an O or B star remains only for a few million years. In the course of their evolution on the main sequence, the stars move away slightly from the ZAMS in the HRD towards somewhat higher luminosities and lower effective temperatures (so towards down right in the diagram). Massive stars can lose part of their initial mass by stellar winds.

Evolution Post Main Sequence

Evolution post the initial phase depends on the stellar mass. Suppose the initial mass of the star is M .

- For $M \leq 0.7 M_{\odot}$

The initial hydrogen burning phase⁴ of such stars is longer than the (estimated) age of the universe⁵. These stars still lie on the main sequence.

- For $M \leq 2.5 M_{\odot}$

Central hydrogen burning is followed by a relatively brief phase of the hydrogen fusing into helium in a shell outside the center of the star. After this phase, the star moves

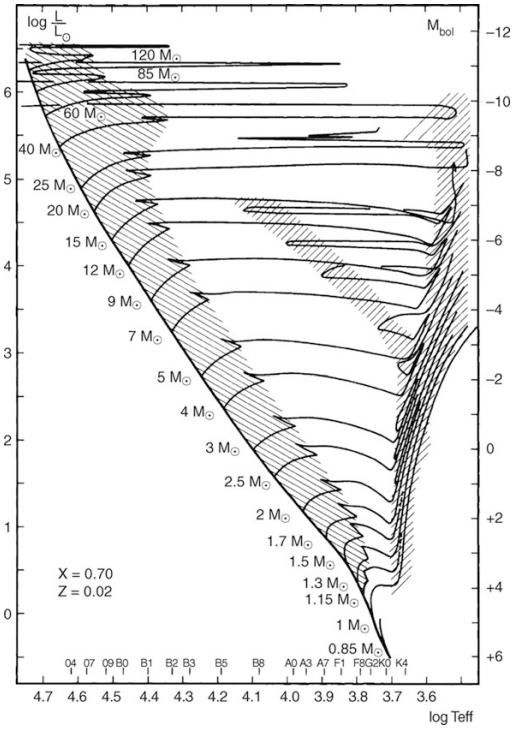


Figure 1.5: The solid line represents the ZAMS in this temperature-luminosity diagram.

⁴Hydrogen burning just refers to its fusion into helium. Similarly, helium burning refers to its fusion into carbon.

⁵The current estimate for the age of the universe is around 13.787 billion years.

right in the HRD (lower effective temperature but same luminosity) and thereby strongly expands (1.5). This causes the temperature and density in the center rise enough so that helium starts fusing into carbon.

This helium burning is very explosive for these stars, resulting in ‘helium flashes’, during which large amounts of stellar mass get ejected. After these flashes, a new stable equilibrium configuration is established with a helium burning shell formed besides the hydrogen burning shell. Expanding its radius, the star will evolve into a red giant or supergiant and move along the asymptotic giant branch (AGB) in the HRD.

- For $M \leq 8M_{\odot}$

After the initial expansion due to the formation of the hydrogen burning shell, these stars have their cores hot and dense enough for ‘quiet’ helium formation. Once the core runs out of helium, a second shell source forms fusing helium. In this stage, the star becomes a red giant or supergiant. A large portion of stellar mass is ejected into the interstellar medium in the form of stellar winds.

The configuration of the helium shell is unstable and it releases flashes (helium is burned) in the form of pulses. After some time, this leads to the ejection of the outer envelope⁶ which then becomes visible as a *planetary nebula*.

At this stage, since the star is shedding its outer envelope, its radius decreases drastically, leading to a very drastic increase in temperature (1.5), moving it left in the HRD. The fuel burning in the core is not affected, hence the luminosity stays mostly the same. However, once the fuel runs out, there is a decrease in the luminosity which leads to a small decrease in the temperature until it cools down to become a *white dwarf* with a mass of about $0.6M_{\odot}$ and a radius roughly the same as that of Earth.

- For $M \geq 8M_{\odot}$

For these stars, the temperature and density at its center become so tremendous that carbon can also be fused. Subsequent stellar evolution leads to a core-collapse supernova, leading to the formation of a neutron star, or for the most massive ones ($\sim M \geq 25M_{\odot}$), a black hole.

⁶The outer envelope is everything apart from the star’s core.

Chapter 2

The World of Galaxies

Ever since the Hubble Deep Field image, the whole of humanity has set their sight to discover what lies far beyond they could ever comprehend. When dealing with extragalactic astronomy, the most notable entities are arguably other galaxies, and this is a chapter all about them.



Figure 2.1: The Hubble Deep Field image produced by *Edwin Hubble* changed the world forever. All the dots in the image are galaxies, not stars.

The light from ‘normal galaxies’ is mainly the sum of all the light emitted by the stars present within it. As we learnt about stars, hot and blue stars have a much shorter lifespan than the cooler red supergiants or giants. Further, white dwarfs are far less luminous than red supergiants or giants, so that older groups of stars primarily look red.

2.1 Classification of Galaxies

2.1.1 Morphological Classification: Hubble Sequence

On the basis of shape or morphology, galaxies have been historically classified into the following categories:

1. **Elliptical Galaxies:** Their isophotes¹ resemble ellipses. They are further subclassified according to the **ellipticity** of the isophotes: $\epsilon = 1 - b/a$, where a , b are the semi-major and semi-minor axes. Then we define $N = 10\epsilon$ which gives us the representation EN for elliptical galaxies. An E7 galaxy is an elliptical galaxy with $b/a = 0.3$.
2. **Spiral Galaxies:** Their isophotes look like spirals. They are subdivided into two classes: *normal spirals* (S’s) and *barred spirals* (SB’s). These subclasses are further classified on the basis of the (decreasing) ratio of bulge to disc luminosity denoted by a, ab, b, bc, c, cd, d. There are also supposed correlations of bulge size (decreasing along the sequence) and spiral arm tightness (increasing along the sequence). The sequence goes from *early type* (Sa, SBab) to *late type spirals* (SBc, Sd). This is a purely historical convention.
3. **Irregular Galaxies** (Irr’s): Galaxies with weak (Irr I) or no (Irr II) regular structure. This adds further subclasses to the Hubble sequence: Sdm, Sm, Im, Ir (m stands for Magellanic², Ir is just irregular).
4. **S0 Galaxies:** They are a transition between ellipticals and spirals, also called *lenticulars*. They contain a bulge and a large enveloping region of relatively unstructured brightness.

Early/Late Type Nomenclature

This is another purely historical convention with somewhat ambiguous definition that stuck along. It has nothing to do with evolutionary stages of the galaxies.

- **Ellipticals** and **S0 galaxies** are referred to as *early type galaxies*.
- **Spiral galaxies** (the remaining) are referred to as *late type galaxies*.

¹Isophotes are contours along which the surface brightness is constant.

²Magellanic Clouds are two irregular dwarf galaxies orbiting the Milky Way. The term *Magellanic Clouds* was reported by the portuguese explorer Ferdinand Magellan’s crew during their expedition.

Note that early-late type galaxies are distinct from early-late type spirals.

2.1.2 Spectral Distribution of Galaxies

In general, Elliptical galaxies appear red and spiral galaxies appear blue. Drawing inference from above, elliptical galaxies must be having a lot more older stars and lesser new star formation in comparison to spirals.

2.1.3 Limitations of Morphological Classification

NEED TO FILL, ADD MT ABU ANGULAR LIMITS HERE AS WELL. 2.5, 1.2, 50CM, 43CM

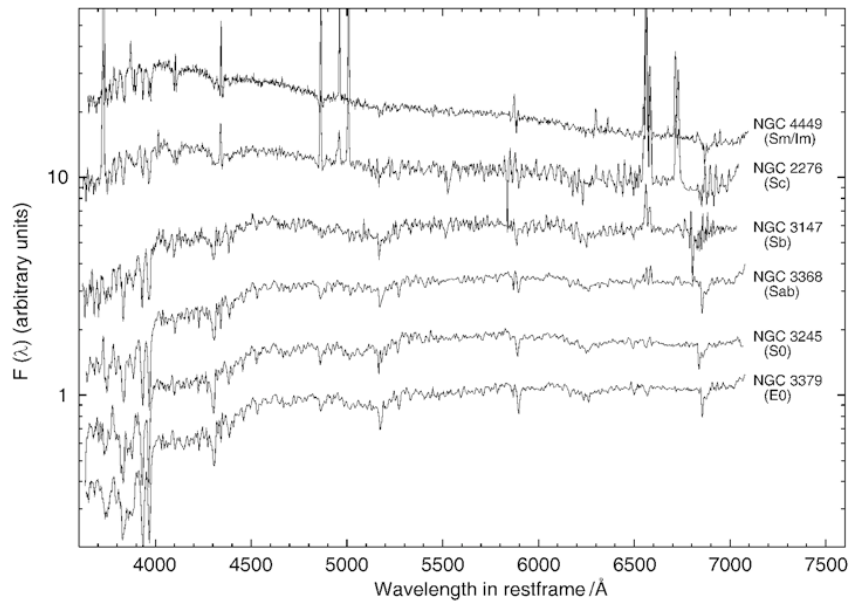


Figure 2.2: Spectra of different kinds of galaxies.

- **Normal Galaxies:** Galaxies whose total spectral distribution can roughly be described as the superposition of the spectra of all of its stars.
- **Active Galaxies:** The spectral distribution of these galaxies have major contribution from gravitational sources: specifically the infall of matter into the Supermassive Black Hole (SMB) at the center of the galaxy. *Active Galactic Nuclei* (AGNs) are a class of such galaxies in which the largest fraction of luminosity is produced in a very small central region: the active galactic nucleus.

2.1.4 Star Formation Rate

- Elliptical galaxies usually have marginal to no star formation.
- Spiral galaxies usually have star formation rates of around $\sim 3M_{\odot}/\text{yr}$.
- Starburst galaxies are those which have very high star formation rates $\sim 10M_{\odot}/\text{yr}$ and more.

2.1.5 Colour of the Galaxies

Plotting the contour plot of the brightness of galaxies for different colours and absolute magnitude, we obtain the Colour-Magnitude Diagram (CMD):

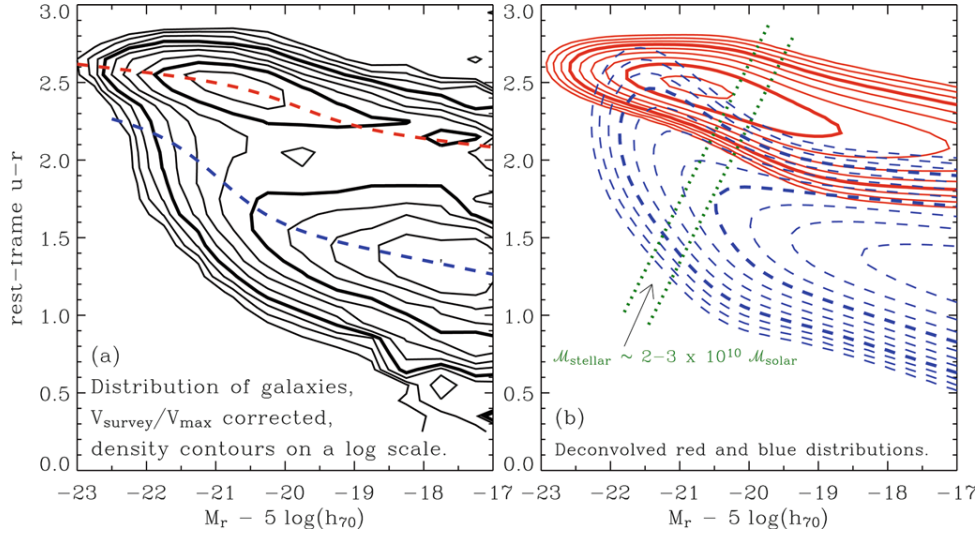


Figure 2.3: CMD showing two peaks of brightness, one at the redder and cooler portion and another at the bluer and hotter portion.

From this diagram we observe that most of the galaxies in the local group are either blue and hot or red and less hot. These two correspond to usual spiral and elliptical galaxies respectively. The local group can be described as a binodal distribution in colour with the characteristic colour having a slight dependence on the absolute magnitude.

A red stellar population does not contain massive luminous stars, leading to a high mass-to-light ratio. As a consequence, a red population of the same brightness would be much more significantly massive than a blue population.

2.2 Elliptical Galaxies

A rough subclassification of elliptical galaxies based on luminosity and size is as follows:

- *Normal Ellipticals*: Consists of giant ellipticals (gE's), those of intermediate luminosity (E's) and compact ellipticals (cE's). $M_B \sim -23$ to -15 .
- *Dwarf Ellipticals* (dE's): Different from cE's because they have a significantly lower surface brightness and a lower metallicity.
- *cD Galaxies*: Extremely luminous ($M_B \sim -25$) and large (up to $R \lesssim 1$ Mpc) galaxies found only at the center of dense clusters of galaxies. With very high surface brightness near the center, they have an extended diffuse envelope. Very high M/L ratio.
- *Blue Compact Dwarf Galaxies* (BCD's): They are very blue ($\langle B-V \rangle$ between 0.0 and 0.3) dwarf galaxies that contain an appreciable amount of gas.
- *Dwarf Spheroidals* (dSph's): Very low luminosity ($M_B \sim -8$) and surface brightness.

Table 2.1: Characteristic values for early-type galaxies

	S0	cD	E	dE	dSph	BCD
M_B	−17 to −22	−22 to −25	−15 to −23	−13 to −19	−8 to −15	−14 to −17
M ($M_\odot$)	10^{10} – 10^{12}	10^{13} – 10^{14}	10^8 – 10^{13}	10^7 – 10^9	10^7 – 10^8	$\sim 10^9$
D_{25} (kpc)	10–100	300–1000	1–200	1–10	0.1–0.5	< 3
$\langle M/L_B \rangle$	~ 10	> 100	10–100	1–10	5–100	0.1–10
$\langle S_N \rangle$	~ 5	~ 15	~ 5	4.8 ± 1.0	–	–

D_{25} denotes the diameter at which the surface brightness has decreased to 25 B-mag/arcsec², S_N is the “specific frequency”, a measure for the number of globular clusters (xi.) in relation to the visual luminosity, and M/L is the mass-to-light ratio in Solar units (the values of this table are taken from the book by Carroll & Ostlie).

2.2.1 Brightness Profile

The brightness profile of a galaxy usually follows the *de Vaucouleur’s profile* which says the surface brightness measured as $\mu \propto -2.5 \log(I)$ is proportional to the $r^{1/4}$ where r is the projected distance from the center. More specifically, we have:

$$\log \left(\frac{I(R)}{I_e} \right) = -3.3307 \left[\left(\frac{R}{R_e} \right)^{1/4} - 1 \right]$$

where R_e is the effective radius (v.) and I_e is the effective intensity (vi.). Another form of the above equation is:

$$I(R) = I_e \exp \left(-7.669 \left[(R/R_e)^{1/4} - 1 \right] \right)$$

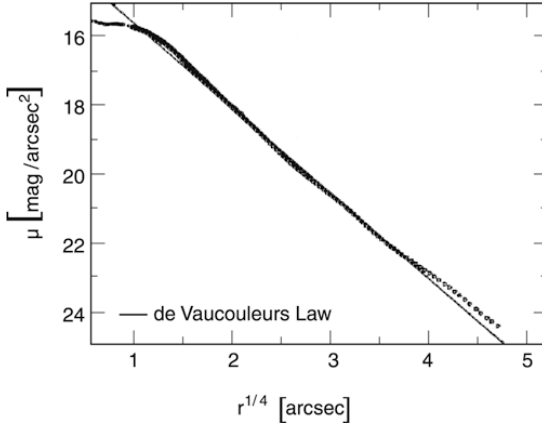


Figure 2.4: Surface brightness of galaxy NGC 4472 fitted with a de Vaucouleur’s profile. It is evident that this galaxy has a light deficit; a core.

The brightness profiles of normal E’s and cD’s (in its innermost parts) approximately follows a de Vaucouleur’s profile. The central brightness profile of ellipticals sometimes lies well below the $r^{1/4}$ fit. Such ellipticals are said to have a *core* or *light deficit*. These are usually very luminous, consequently also having very high stellar masses. The opposite can also happen with an *excess of light* in the central region of the galaxy, typically having lower luminosity and thus lower stellar mass.

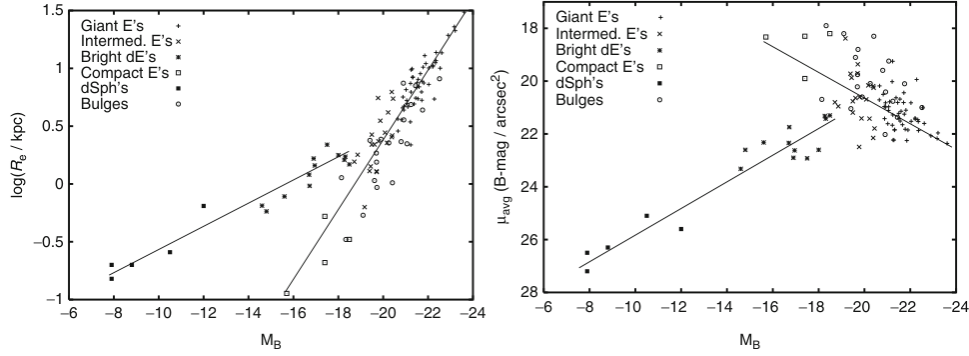


Figure 2.5: *Left*: effective radius R_e vs absolute magnitude M_B . *Right*: avg surface brightness μ_{avg} vs absolute magnitude M_B .

2.2.2 Chemical Composition

Many ellipticals (up to 75%) contain visible amounts of dust, manifested partially in the form of a dust disk; frequently extended disks of cold gas (HI), upto $\sim 200\text{kpc}$ in diameter.

Star Formation

Star formation is low but not existent. Around 15% of red galaxies showed a strong UV excess according to UV-observations from GALEX. Around 75% of them show clear signs of star formation. The UV emission (that signifies O and B stars primarily³, which have a relatively short lifespan) is more extended than the optical image of the galaxies, indicating that the star formation occurs in the outer parts of the galaxy.

Metallicity

The metallicity of ellipticals and S0 galaxies increase towards the galaxy center, as derived from the colour gradients. S0 bulges also appear redder than the disk.

2.2.3 Dynamics of Elliptical Galaxies

We can tell from doppler measurements if a galaxy is rotating (unless it's directly face-on). We consequently try to understand how they are stable in time or in such shape and motion to begin.

Cause of Ellipticity

If rotation of the ellipticals were the only reason for their flattening from supposed 'spherical' galaxies, it can be shown through stellar dynamics that the rotational speed of the galaxy v_{rot} and velocity dispersion⁴, σ_v , has to obey:

$$\left(\frac{v_{\text{rot}}}{\sigma_v}\right)_{\text{iso}} = \sqrt{\frac{\epsilon}{1 - \epsilon}}$$

³Out of all the spectral classes of stars. There are other sources of UV like AGNs.

⁴Measure of how much the stars are moving randomly in comparison to the mean velocity, just like gas molecules in random motion because of their thermal energy.

where ϵ is the ellipticity. While this could have been an explanation for ellipticals of low luminosity or bulges of disks, in general, for ellipticals with very high luminosity, $v_{\text{rot}} \ll \sigma_v$, so that rotation cannot be a major cause of the ellipticity.

Relaxation Time-scale

The brightness profile of an elliptical galaxy is determined by the distribution of its stellar orbits. We know from redshift measurements that galaxies rotate. Constructing initial position and velocity distributions that result in ellipticals not being stationary and being self-gravitating equilibrium systems is a difficult mathematical problem in general.

Assuming that close interactions of stars could lead to significant disruption in stellar orbits, *section 3.2.4 of Schneider* [ADD REFERENCE](#) explains how the relaxation time turns out to be longer than the age of the universe, considering all stars of equal masses and extents.

We thus conclude that stars behave like a collision-less gas: they are stabilized by dynamical pressure, and they are elliptical because the stellar distribution is anisotropic in velocity space. This corresponds to an anisotropic pressure.

NEED TO EXPLAIN WHY LATER

2.3 Spiral Galaxies

Some trends are observed in the sequence of spiral galaxies, useful for early-late spiral classification:

- decreasing luminosity ratio of with $L_{\text{bulge}}/L_{\text{disc}} \sim 0.5$ for Sa's and ~ 0.03 for Sc's,
- increasing opening angle for the spiral arms, from $\sim 6^\circ$ for Sa's to $\sim 18^\circ$ for Sc's,
- and increasing structure of the isophotes: Sa's have a 'smooth' distribution of stars along their spiral arms whereas Sc's have bright knots and HII regions.

Spirals also have lesser variation in their parameters of absolute magnitude and stellar mass in comparison to ellipticals. They range from $-16 \gtrsim M_B \gtrsim -23$ mag in terms of luminosity and $10^9 M_\odot \lesssim M \lesssim 10^{12} M_\odot$ in terms of stellar mass. Around 70% of all disk galaxies contain a large-scale stellar bar.

The morphology of spirals can be expanded according to the value of scale-height across the different stellar populations:

- **Young Thin Disk:** This component contains the largest fraction of gas and dust. Star formation is active and the youngest stars can be found on this thin disk. Scale-height is the smallest.
- **Old Thin Disk:** This component is thicker and contains older stars.

- **Thick Disk:** This component is significantly thicker and consists of older, metal-poor stars with a higher velocity dispersion perpendicular to the disk plane. Scale-height is the largest.

Note that the scale-height corresponds to the age of the stellar population.

Table 2.2: Characteristic values for spiral galaxies

	Sa	Sb	Sc	Sd/Sm	Im/Ir
M_B	−17 to −23	−17 to −23	−16 to −22	−15 to −20	−13 to −18
M ($M_\odot$)	10^9 – 10^{12}	10^9 – 10^{12}	10^9 – 10^{12}	10^8 – 10^{10}	10^8 – 10^{10}
$\langle L_{\text{bulge}}/L_{\text{tot}} \rangle_B$	0.3	0.13	0.05	–	–
Diam. (D_{25} , kpc)	5–100	5–100	5–100	0.5–50	0.5–50
$\langle M/L_B \rangle$ ($M_\odot/L_\odot$)	6.2 ± 0.6	4.5 ± 0.4	2.6 ± 0.2	~ 1	~ 1
V_{max} range (km s $^{-1}$)	163–367	144–330	99–304	–	50–70
Opening angle	$\sim 6^\circ$	$\sim 12^\circ$	$\sim 18^\circ$	–	–
$\mu_{0,B}$ (mag arcsec $^{-2}$)	21.52 ± 0.39	21.52 ± 0.39	21.52 ± 0.39	22.61 ± 0.47	22.61 ± 0.47
$\langle B - V \rangle$	0.75	0.64	0.52	0.47	0.37
$\langle M_{\text{gas}}/M_{\text{tot}} \rangle$	0.04	0.08	0.16	0.25 (Scd)	–
$\langle M_{H_2}/M_{HI} \rangle$	2.2 ± 0.6 (Sab)	1.8 ± 0.3	0.73 ± 0.13	0.19 ± 0.10	–
$\langle S_N \rangle$	1.2 ± 0.2	1.2 ± 0.2	0.5 ± 0.2	0.5 ± 0.2	–

V_{max} is the maximum rotation velocity, thus characterizing the flat part of the rotation curve. The opening angle is the angle under which the spiral arms branch off, i.e., the angle between the tangent to the spiral arms and the circle around the center of the galaxy running through this tangential point. S_N is the specific abundance of globular clusters as defined in (3.18).

2.3.1 Brightness Profile

The brightness profile of the bulge follows the de Vaucouleur’s profile to a first approximation. The disk (face-on) follows an exponential profile. Expressing these distributions of the surface brightness $\mu \propto -2.5 \log(I)$, we have:

$$\mu_{\text{bulge}}(R) = \mu_e + 8.3268 \left[\left(\frac{R}{R_e} \right)^{1/4} - 1 \right] \quad (2.1)$$

and

$$\mu_{\text{disk}}(R) = \mu_0 + 1.09 \left(\frac{R}{h_R} \right) \quad (2.2)$$

where μ_e is the surface brightness at R_e , h_R is the scale-length (i.) and μ_0 is the central surface brightness of the disk component, which is measured by fitting the sum of the above equations to the total light profile of the galaxy.

The brightness profile of the edge of the spirals is exponential. The scale-height h_z (ii.) is almost independent from the galacto-centric radius⁵ R and scales roughly with the rotational

⁵Distance of an object from the center of the galaxy.

velocity of the disk v_{rot} .

$$\mu_{\text{edge}}(z) = \mu_0 + 1.09 \left(\frac{|z|}{h_z} \right) \quad (2.3)$$

The typical value of the ratio of scale-height to scale-length is $h_R/h_z \sim 0.07$.

Bulges and Pseudobulges

Classical bulges follow the de Vaucouleur's profile. However, there exist bulges which don't follow the de Vaucouleur's profile and instead follow a more exponential profile and are flatter. These bulges are called *pseudobulges*. Classical bulges lie on the same sequence as ellipticals on the effective radius vs absolute magnitude graph (Fig. 2.5), however the pseudobulges have lower luminosity for the same effective radius. Classical bulges contain about 10 times more stars than pseudobulges.

Some late type spirals have no bulge at the center but instead a nuclear stellar cluster, whose luminosity is dominated by a relatively young stellar population but whose stellar mass is dominated by an old population.

Freeman's Law

Freeman's law says that for 'normal spirals', the variation of central surface brightness μ_0 is very less across different galaxies. For Sa to Sc's⁶, $\mu_0 = 21.52 \pm 0.39$ B-mag/arcsec² and for Sd and later types, $\mu_0 = 22.61 \pm 0.47$ B-mag/arcsec².

This however does not apply to *low surface brightness galaxies (LSBs)*. These galaxies have μ_0 2 or more orders lesser in magnitude, making them very hard to detect at larger distances. They have much slower star formation rates.

Warps in Disks

The disk warps out of the plane of the galactic disk where most stars and gas rotate. In most cases, the warps start at radii beyond the optical radius of the galaxy, hence only visible in the distribution and motion of gas (primarily neutral hydrogen atom gas HI).

Stellar Halo

Stellar halos of distant galaxies is hard to study due to their low surface brightness. In our neighbouring galaxy M31, the Andromeda galaxy, a stellar halo of red giant branch (RGB) stars was detected which extends out to more than 150 kpc. For radii $r \lesssim 20$ kpc, it follows the extrapolation from the bulge surface brightness, but for

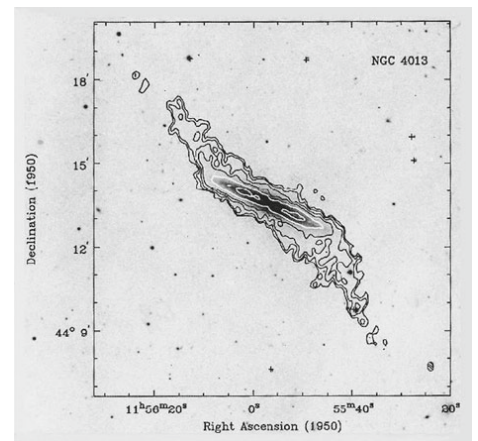


Figure 2.6: Edge-on spiral NGC4013, optical emission in grey, superimposed by intensity of cold 21-cm emitting gas (HI). The warping begins only about when the visible disk ends.

⁶B-mag refers to the magnitude measured in Johnson blue band.

larger radii, it follows a radial density profile of roughly $\rho \sim r^{-3}$.

Thick Disk

This component (2.3) can only be studied for edge-on spirals. The scale height of a stellar population increases with its age. For luminous disk galaxies, the thick disk does not have any substantial contribution to the luminosity. However, for lower-mass disk galaxies with rotational velocities $\lesssim 120$ km/s, the thick disk stars contribute nearly half of their luminosity and may dominate the stellar mass. This results in the dominant stellar population of these galaxies being old despite it appearing blue.

Sizes of Disks

Typically, the optical radius of a spiral galaxy extends out to about $4h_R$ (break radius), after which the surface brightness, and thus the stellar surface density, displays a break. The characteristic surface brightness at which this occurs is $\mu_B \approx 25.5$ mag/arcsec². Although there are many exceptions to this behavior, it still prevails in the majority of spirals. In contrast to the stellar distribution, neutral gas is observed to considerably larger radius, typically upto twice the break radius.

2.3.2 Chemical Composition

Star Formation

Stars form from gas only where its surface mass density, Σ_{gas} (measured in $M_{\odot} \text{pc}^{-2}$), exceeds a certain value. Marteen Schmidt in 1959 proposed its relation to the star formation rate per unit area, Σ_{SFR} (measured in $M_{\odot} \text{yr}^{-1} \text{kpc}^{-2}$) as:

$$\Sigma_{\text{SFR}} \propto \Sigma_{\text{gas}}^N$$

with power law index of $N \approx 1.4$. Detailed later by Rob Kennicutt, the new Schmidt-Kennicutt law now stands at:

$$\frac{\Sigma_{\text{SFR}}}{M_{\odot} \text{yr}^{-1} \text{kpc}^{-2}} = (2.5 \pm 0.7) \times 10^{-4} \left(\frac{\Sigma_{\text{gas}}}{M_{\odot} \text{pc}^{-2}} \right)^{1.40 \pm 0.15}$$

Because of the apparent absence of star formation in the outer parts of spiral galaxies, this relation is complemented with a cutoff Σ_{gas} .

This graph shows data of star formation rates against availability of hydrogen for normal spirals, LSBs and starburst galaxies. Globally, the graph can be fitted by a power law of $N = 1.4$. However, for starburst galaxies (right) and normal spirals (center), a linear relation seems to hold well ($N \sim 1$) whereas the rate sharply decreases for the rest of the galaxies (left).

2.3.3 Composition and Gas Fractions

For this section, it is helpful to write everything in pointers. The following are the trends for the Spiral Hubble classification from Sa to Sd:

- i. $B - V$ decreases: ~ 0.75 for Sa's, 0.64 for Sb's, 0.52 for Sc's and 0.4 for Irr's.
- ii. This signifies increasing fraction of massive, young stars. This is in agreement with the bright knots found in later type spirals which have high star formation activity.
- iii. Colour sequence also in agreement with decreasing bulge fraction.
- iv. Gas fraction increases, measured HI, H α and CO emissions. This again aligns with increasing star formation. Some characteristic values of $M_{\text{gas}}/M_{\text{baryon}}$ ⁷ are about 0.04 for Sa's, 0.08 for Sb's, 0.16 for Sc's and 0.25 for Irr's. Earlier type galaxies seem to have been more efficient at star formation.
- v. Fraction of molecular gas relative to the total gas mass is decreasing.
- vi. Dust is the biggest source of far-infrared (FIR) emission from galaxies. Sc's emit more FIR than Sa's. Barred spirals have stronger FIR emissions than normal spirals.

Spirals don't necessarily emit isotropically but mean dust extinction is higher when the galaxy is edge-on. Comparing the colour of spirals at different inclinations, we find the typical extinction of an edge-on galaxy to be $0.7, 0.6, 0.5, 0.4$ for u, g, r, i-bands resp. This effect is weaker for lower-mass spirals, indicating that their relative dust content is smaller than that of high-mass spirals.

Metallicity

Metallicity increases inwards towards the bulge; metal-rich stars are redder than metal-poor ones, due to their high opacity. Metallicity of spirals also increases with luminosity.

⁷Baryons are composite subatomic particles with an odd number of valence quarks. Protons and neutrons are baryons. They have half-integer spins and thus follow Fermi-Dirac statistics.

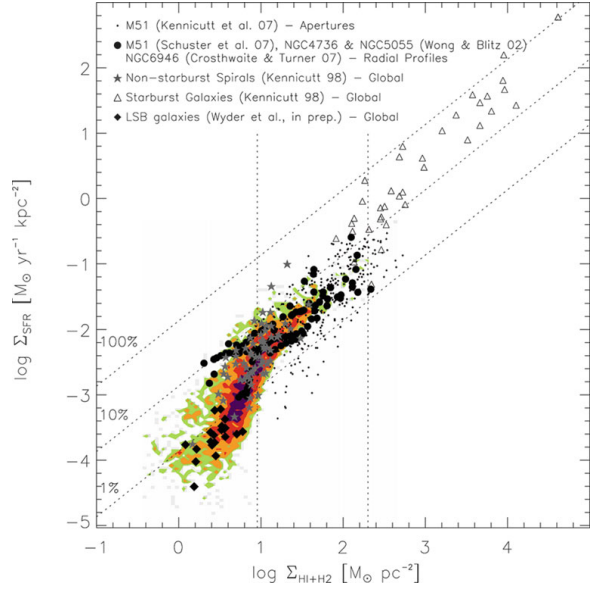


Figure 2.7: The diagonal lines show how long it will take to deplete available gas reservoir, corresponding to time scales of $10^8, 10^9$ and 10^{10} from top to bottom. Regime between the vertical lines are occupied by normal spiral galaxies.

Spirals have a clear colour gradient: they are red in the center and bluer in the outer regions. This could be explained by metallicity increasing inwards. Additionally, lower gas fraction in the bulge leads to less star formation and thus, in general, older redder stars than the outer regions.

Globular Clusters

Early type and more luminous galaxies usually have more globular clusters (xi.). A way to measure the *specific abundance* of globular clusters can be by normalising the total number of observed globular clusters N_t to a galaxy with absolute magnitude $M_V = -15$ corresponding to a luminosity of $L_V = L_{15}$. We thus get the following form for specific abundance:

$$S_N = N_t \frac{L_{15}}{L_V} = N_t 10^{0.4(M_V+15)}$$

S_N is larger for ellipticals than spirals, with cD galaxies having the largest values. $S_N \sim 1.2$ for Sa's and Sb's and ~ 0.5 for Sc's.

Spiral Structure

Spiral structure appears much bluer than the rest of the galaxy due to stars being actively formed here. It is possible that they were formed by perturbation of the gravitational potential by the bar of the galaxy or companion galaxies. They are suspected to be density waves. According to that, the rotational velocity is not the same as the velocity of the stars.

Using 21 cm observations of spiral galaxies, in 1977 R. Brent Tully and J. Richard Fisher found that the maximum rotation velocity, $v_{\max}$ of spirals is closely related to their luminosity, following the relation:

$$L \propto v_{\max}^\alpha$$

where $\alpha \sim 4$.

2.4 Atlas of Galaxy Spectra

The following has been taken from *A Spectrophotometric Atlas of Galaxies* by Kennicutt, 1992.

The spectral flux $F(\lambda)$ of the following spectra has been normalised according to a reference wavelength of 550 nm so as to allow comparisons. The captions from the original paper were sufficient so I let them be.

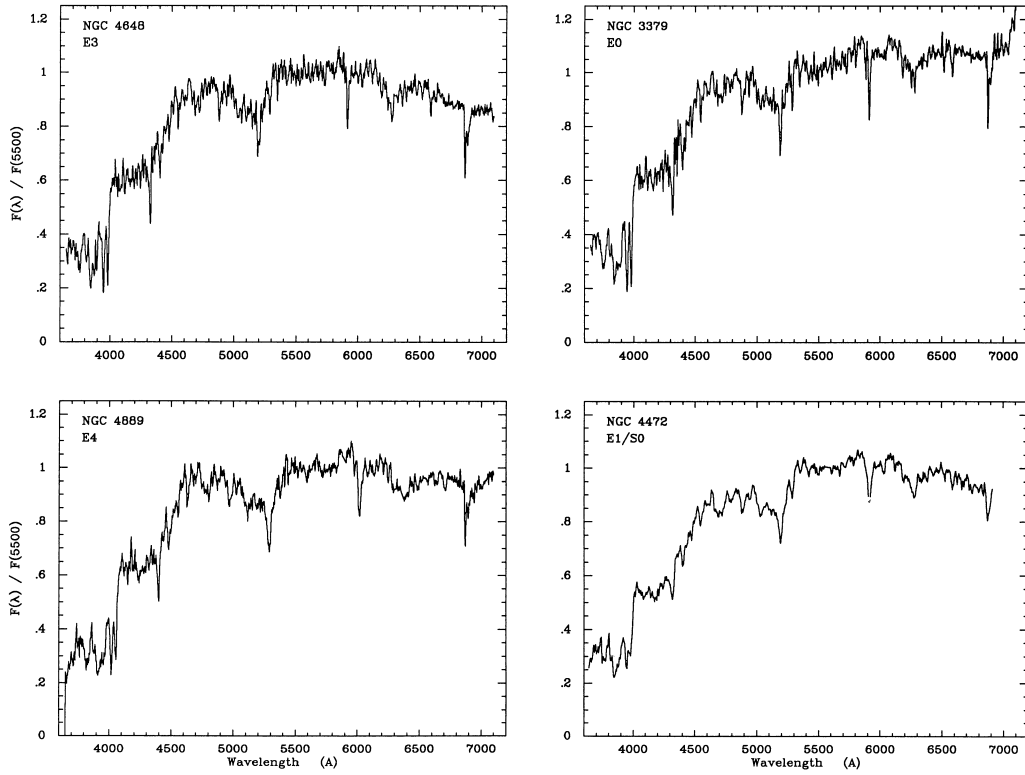


FIG. 5.—Integrated spectra of four elliptical galaxies. The spectrum of NGC 4472 (*lower right*) was obtained at lower resolution with the IRS scanner.

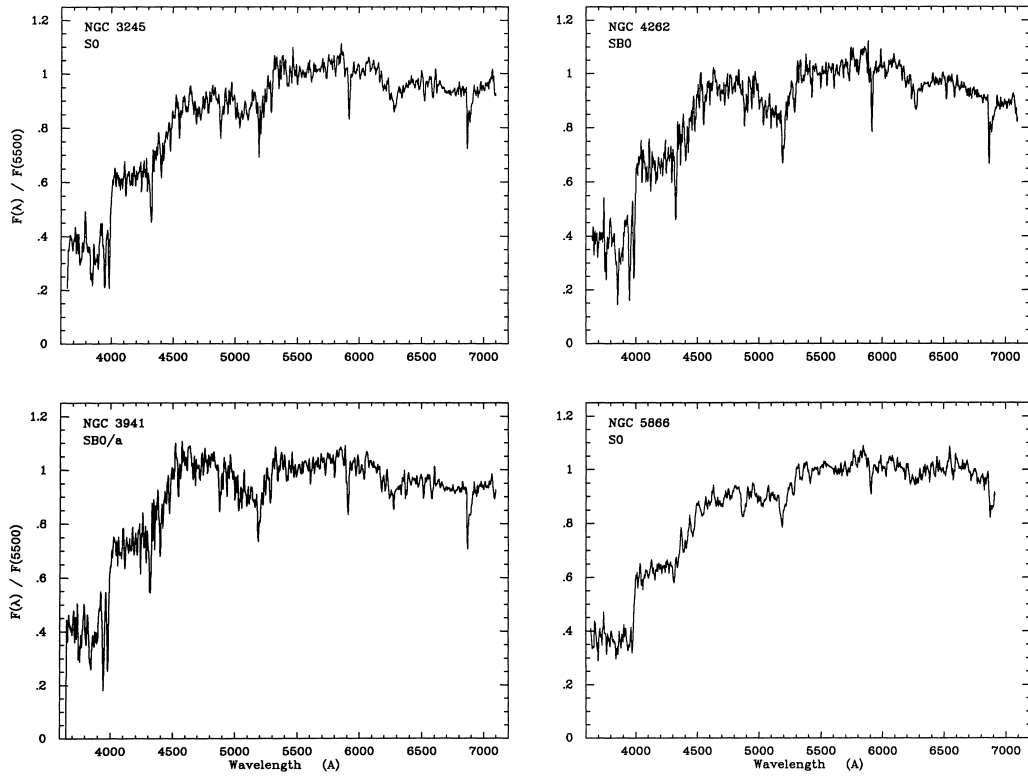


FIG. 6.—Integrated spectra of four S0 galaxies. The spectrum of NGC 5866 (*lower right*) was obtained at lower resolution with the IRS scanner.

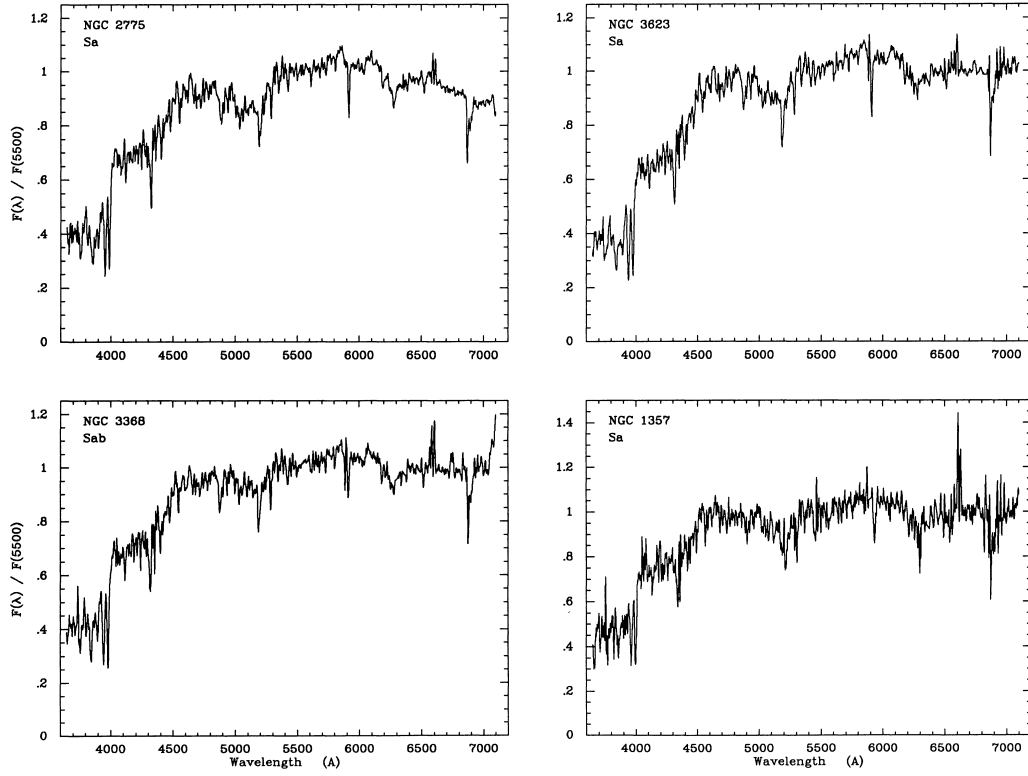


FIG. 7.—Integrated spectra of four Sa-Sab galaxies

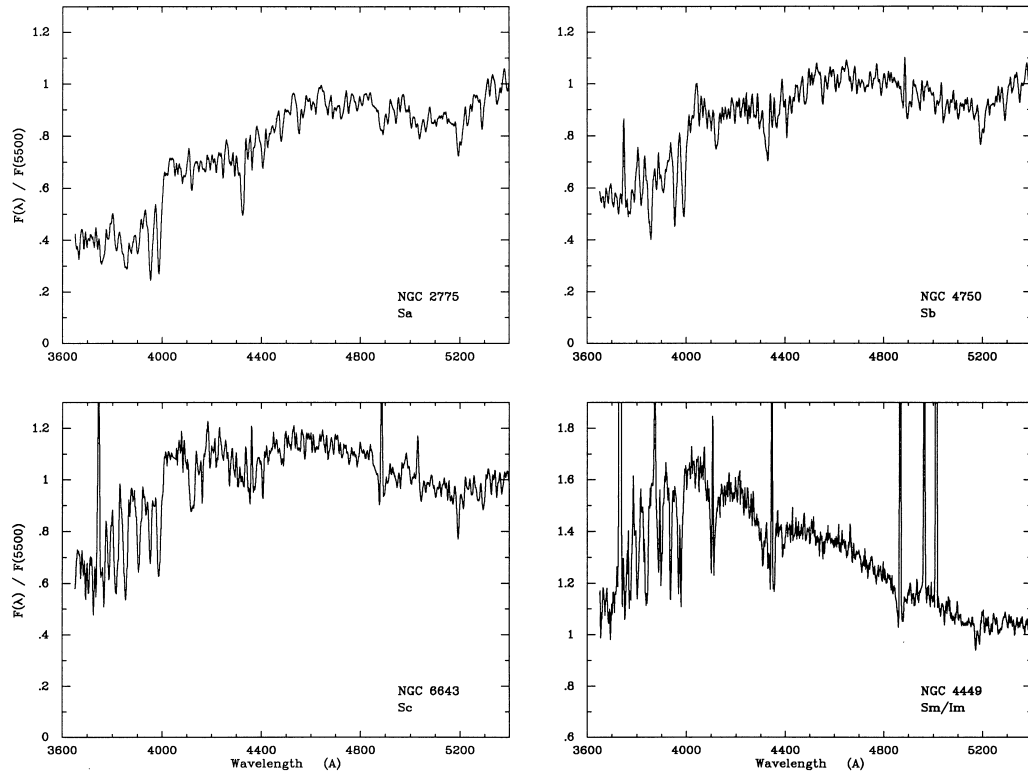


FIG. 12.—Expanded plots of the integrated blue spectra for four spiral and irregular galaxies, illustrating the progression in continuum energy distributions and absorption-line spectra along the Hubble sequence.

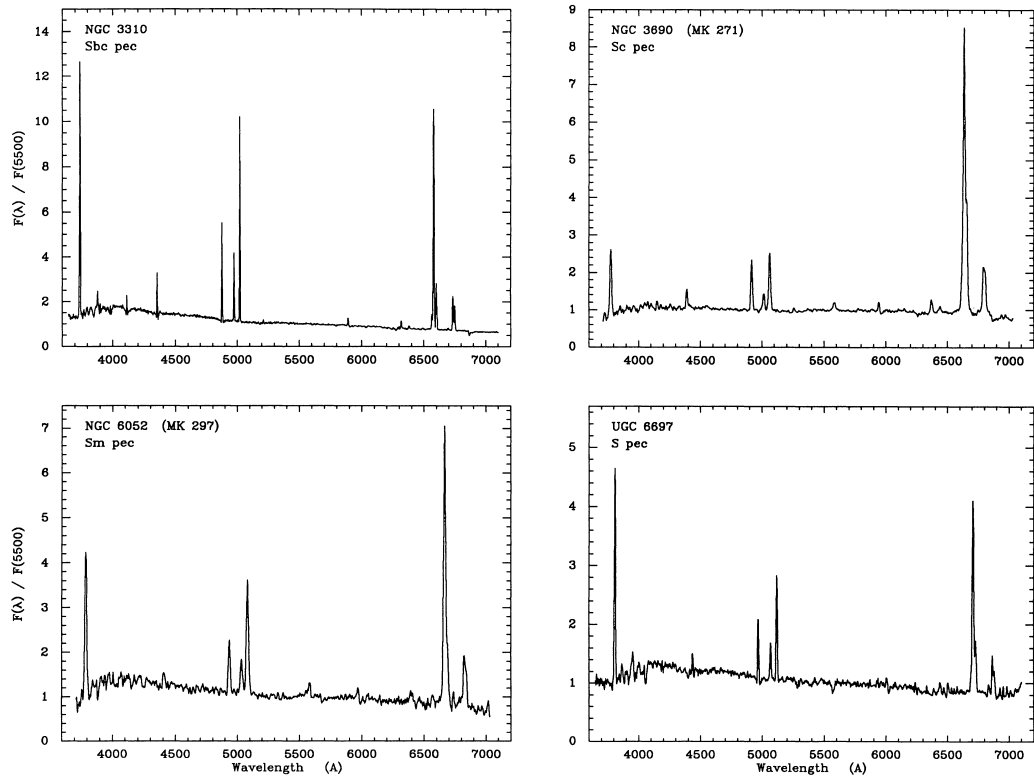


FIG. 16.—Integrated spectra of four spiral and irregular galaxies with global starbursts

Chapter 3

Active Galactic Nuclei

- need to mention about why there's a gap in the spectra for the agns, the reason being absorption by neutral hydrogen in the intergalactic space.

As we had discussed earlier, a galaxy with an compact nucleus that has very high luminosity across a much larger range of wavelengths is called an *active galaxy*. The nucleus is then called the *Active Galactic Nucleus* (AGN). It is still unclear whether being active is a phase of galaxies or whether they're a distinct class of galaxies by themselves, showing less correlation with the morphology.

3.1 Common Characteristics

- Compact nuclei $R \lesssim 1$ pc producing high luminosity
- Much broader *Spectral Emission Distribution* (SED) (x.) in comparison to normal galaxies.
- Stronger and broader emission (and absorption) lines in comparison to other galaxies.
- Peak emission in X-ray or ultraviolet regions usually. This is referred to as the 'big blue bump'.
- They often have extended lobes connected to the nucleus by jets.

Active galaxies are classified into quasars, Seyfert galaxies, blazars and radio galaxies. The morphology of AGNs usually includes a compact central source and other extended sources, usually nearly symmetric double sources in the form of radio lobes. These lobes are often connected to the central core by jets, which are emission structures of some sort.

Over a broad range of wavelengths, AGNs follow a

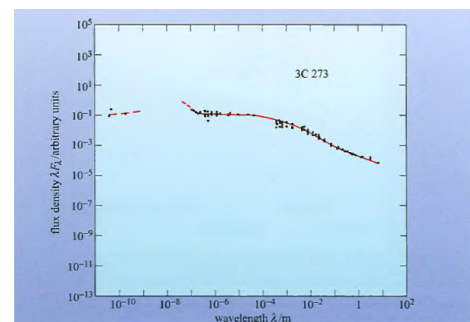


Figure 3.1: SED of an active galaxy (quasar) 3C 273. We can observe the big blue bump in the X-ray and UV regions. Source: Ref. 2

power law:

$$S_\nu \propto \nu^{-\alpha} \quad (3.1)$$

where α is the spectral index.

Note: The gap in the SED in Fig. 3.1 around where the peak should be is caused due to interstellar absorption in our own galaxy. The so-called EUV Dark Zone is due to absorption by galactic neutral hydrogen HI in the Milky Way. NOT SURE ABOUT THIS.

3.2 Classification of Extended Radio Sources

Fanaroff-Riley Type I (FRI) are brightest closest to the core and surface brightness decreases outwards, while for FRII, the surface brightness is higher further from the core, and they have higher luminosities in general.

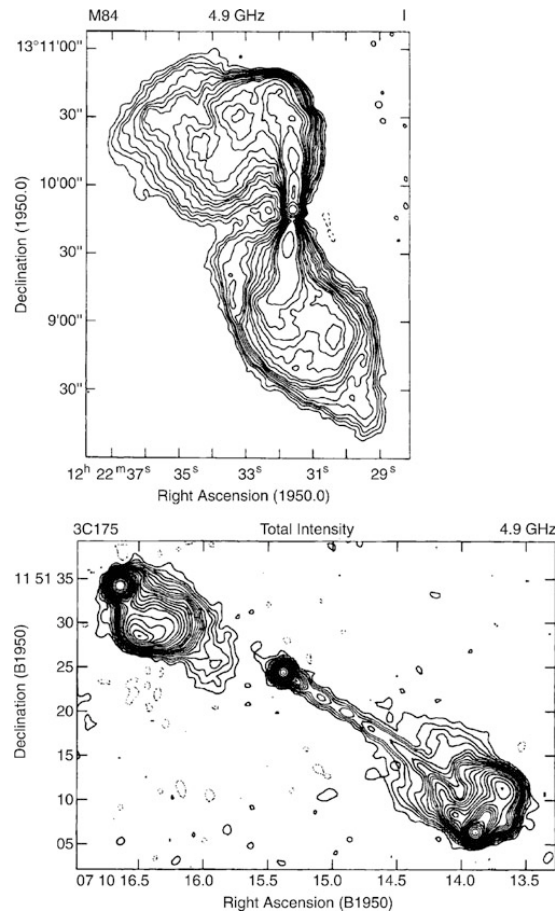


Figure 3.2: Radio galaxies M84 with FNI (top) and 3C175 with FNII (bottom) extended radio sources. Source: Ref 1

As can be seen in the FNII example, most often, only one of the jets is visible, with the other being very weak or non-existent.

3.3 Source of Energy Spectrum

For eq. 3.1, over a broad range of wavelengths, $\alpha \sim 0.7$ (3.1) for extended components and $\alpha \sim 0$ for the compact core. Radio emission is often linearly polarised (degree of polarisation upto $\sim 30\%$ or more). This suggests that the radiation is caused by [synchrotron radiation](#), where relativistic (at speeds $\geq 0.1c$) electrons are subject to magnetic fields. If this is to be the primary source of the energy spectrum, to produce wavelengths in the cm range, the electrons need to be highly relativistic, necessitating extremely efficient processes of particle acceleration.

The characteristic time t_{cool} in which a relativistic electron loses its energy is comparable to the age of the sources for low-frequency radio emissions. However, for high-frequency emissions, like those in the optical range, the lifetimes are considerably smaller than the age of the sources and the distance spanned by the complete structure including all the extended sources. This means that the particle acceleration has to happen locally in the extended sources as well, since they don't live long enough to travel from the core.

The classification of AGNs can be mostly understood, to a first approximation, by geometric considerations. The emissions have a preferred axis, the one vertical to the accreting disk of the central Super Massive Black Hole. To help with understanding the classification, we go over the outline of the unified model describing them.

3.4 Outline of Unified Model

Surrounding the central supermassive black hole is an accretion disk which emits the bulk part of the optical and UV continuum emission. The central region around the accretion disk is the source of most of the X-ray radiation. Gas clouds above and below the accretion disk are responsible for the broad emission lines (these clouds move at highly variable speeds from 1,000 to 10,000 km/s). In the plane of the disk, a distribution of gas and dust is present, which can absorb radiation from the inner region of the AGN. The appearance of the AGN depends on the direction of line-of-sight relative to the disk axis. Broad line emissions might be fully obscured for an observer in the plane of the disk. In contrast, the gas responsible for the narrow emission lines is located at much larger distances from the black hole, so that it cannot be fully hidden by the obscuring 'torus'.

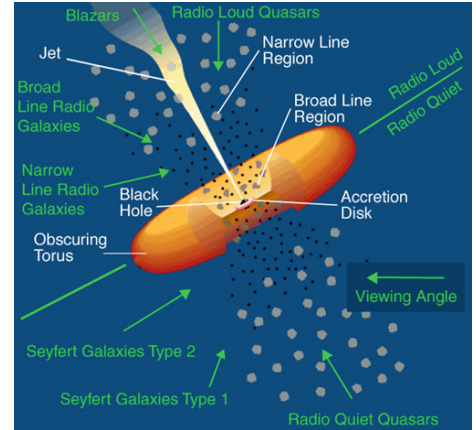


Figure 3.3: Schematic of the current understanding of unification of AGN types. The green arrows indicate lines-of-sight to observers, labelled with characteristic AGN class.

The radio jets are launched very close to the central black hole along the direction of the disk axis. The emission from these jets is highly anisotropic, because the velocity in the inner part of the jets is close to the speed of light; then, according to the theory of Special Relativity, the jet emission is strongly beamed in the direction of jet motion. This implies that the appearance of

the jet depends on how close the line-of-sight to an observer is to the jet axis. If the jet points almost directly at the observer, the jet emission can outshine all the other radiation from the AGN. With this information, we proceed to the classification of AGNs:

3.5 AGN Zoology

3.5.1 Quasars

Point-like objects similar to stars but having spectra quite unlike stars, these *quasi-stellar radio sources* (QSRs) or *quasi-stellar objects* (QSOs) are the most luminous AGNs. They were discovered by identifying radio sources with point-like optical sources. They have wide broadband emissions with variability time-scale differing for different objects and wavelengths.

The flux of the source varies across almost all wavelengths and so does the variability time-scale. In general, it is observed that the variability time-scale of the radiation is smaller and amplitude larger, at higher frequencies. The optical spectrum of quasars is very blue, most at redshifts $z \lesssim 2$ having $U - B < -0.3$. Additionally, very broad emission lines are characteristic of the optical and UV spectrum, often with FWHM $\sim 10,000$ km/s, while narrower emission lines still have widths of several 1,000 km/s, still broader than typical velocities of galaxies.